

Unit 2 teacher notes

Sequencing across the two-week block

The unit is built to be taught in order, and the dependency is real rather than presentational: Topic 2.4 applies the models from Topic 2.3, which assume the codes from Topic 2.2.

A workable division for Weeks 4 and 5 is Topic 2.1 and Topic 2.2 in the first week, Topic 2.3 early in the second, and Topic 2.4 with the unit assessment at the end. If the block is compressed, compress Topic 2.2 rather than Topic 2.3. The codes can be read; the models need to be worked through with a group.

Topic 2.3 is the load-bearing topic of the unit. If only one topic is taught well, it should be that one, because it is what the trainee will still be using in five years.

The misconceptions that recur, and how to handle them

Four come up almost every cohort. Each is named inside the topic that corrects it, but they are worth anticipating.

"Ethics is just being a good person, so it cannot be taught." The strongest counter is not an argument but the Miss Rabia case in Topic 2.1: a conscientious, well-meaning teacher who wronged a pupil, where more decency would not have helped. Let the class reach that conclusion rather than asserting it.

"If it is not in the code, it is allowed." Trainees who have worked in tightly-regulated settings hold this firmly. The nested-circles figure in Topic 2.2 is designed for this moment; the gaps between the rings are the point of the diagram.

"Knowing what is right is enough." This is what Rest's model exists to defeat. The two teachers in the Topic 2.3 vignette, one who did not notice and one who noticed and did not act, are the fastest route to it.

"A dilemma means there must be a right answer I have not found yet."

The most persistent of the four. Trainees search for the costless option and become frustrated. Name it early in Topic 2.4: something will be lost, and the professional task is to choose where the loss falls and to limit it.

Running the activities safely

Three of the four activities ask trainees to discuss real cases. Two cautions.

Anonymity is not optional. In the Topic 2.4 dilemma exchange, trainees write accounts of real situations. Establish before they start that no pupil, teacher or school may be identifiable, and be willing to stop an account that drifts into identification. A cohort that has watched you enforce this once will handle the rest of the unit more honestly, not less.

Some accounts will involve harm to the trainee. Where a trainee's own schooling included humiliation or worse, the Topic 2.1 activity can reach it unexpectedly. Give an explicit alternative: any trainee may work from a hypothetical rather than a remembered case, with no explanation required, and say so before the activity rather than afterwards.

If a trainee discloses something that suggests a current safeguarding concern, that is not a teaching moment. Follow your institution's procedure.

The activity that most often goes wrong

The Topic 2.1 sorting activity produces an argument about item 3, the teacher who does not pray, and about item 8, the teacher who lends money to a family. This is by design; both sit on the boundary between personal morality and professional ethics.

The failure mode is that the group settles it by majority and moves on. Intervene if that happens. The value is entirely in the disagreement, and the instruction to spend the last five minutes on the one placement they disagree about exists to force it. Ask the group to state what would have to be true for the other placement to be correct.

Practical work

Observation task (Week 4). The Topic 2.1 practicum task, tallying which pupils a teacher calls on, produces the unit's most reliable evidence that routine decisions carry ethical weight. Collect the half-page reflections and read a selection aloud, anonymised, at the start of Week 5. Trainees discount the point when they read it; they accept it when they hear three peers report the same pattern.

Decision log (Week 5). The Topic 2.3 log is the transfer task that matters most. Set it on the first day of Week 5 so there is a full week of entries. Do not collect it. Ask instead, in the final session, how many found the same Rest component recurring in their own entries; a show of hands makes the point without requiring anyone to disclose.

Code audit (either week). The Topic 2.2 practicum task assumes the school has a written code. Many will not. Prepare for that answer: ask those trainees what fills the gap instead, and the resulting list of unwritten local norms is usually a better discussion than the document would have been.

Marking the unit assessment

The bank is on the unit assessment page with model answers and analytic rubrics. Two notes.

The RRQ mark schemes are point-by-point and total more than a typical paper would carry; select from them rather than setting all ten.

For the ERQs, the rubric caps a response that does not reach "Adequate" on the analysis criterion at 10 out of 20, whatever its other merits. This is deliberate. A fluent, well-organised answer that never analyses anything is the most common

strong-looking weak response at this level, and the cap is what stops it scoring like a good one.

Tip: select any text on this page first to comment on that specific passage - or leave nothing selected for general feedback.

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